

ELPA21 Task Practice

Teacher Edition · Grades 9–12 · Emerging and Progressing

Administration notes, read-aloud scripts, question sets, proficiency look-fors, and four-lane differentiation for the eight tasks in the student packet.

Original practice content written for Laurel High School and modeled on ELPA21 task types. Not an ELPA21 publication and not a released test form.

Before you start

- **Practice the format, not the answers.** The value of these tasks is that students stop being surprised by the task type in the spring. Score them formatively.
- **Administer listening tasks the way the test does.** No text in front of the student, two readings, natural pace. Reading them slowly and loudly does not make them comprehensible.
- **Record the speaking tasks.** Students hear their own fluency, and you get evidence for the LSP file and for Flashlight360 monitoring.
- **Use the four lanes.** Every task lists a Newcomer, Emerging, Progressing, and Challenge version so the whole block runs on one plan.
- **Log what you see.** The look-fors are written as observable behaviors so they can go straight into a progress note.

Task overview

#	Domain	Task type	Context	Materials
1	Writing	Construct a Claim	School Schedule	Notice, frames
2	Writing	Respond to a Message	Email	Email prompt
3	Speaking	Observe and Report	Club Sign-Ups	Graph, recorder
4	Speaking	State an Opinion	Work and School	Prompt read aloud, recorder

5	Listening	Follow Instructions	Following a Procedure	Script (teacher only)
6	Listening	Academic Lecture or Discussion	Science Lecture	Script (teacher only)
7	Reading	Extended Informational Set	Career Pathways	Passage and graph
8	Reading	Short Paragraph	Biography	Passage

Task 1 – Construct a Claim

Writing · School Schedule

What it practices

Writing · construct a claim with reasons and evidence. Mirrors the ELPA21 extended writing task, where students state a position and support it.

Administration

Read the notice aloud once while students follow along, then have them reread it silently before writing. Allow 15–20 minutes for the paragraph.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	A claim in one sentence, one reason, heavy frame use. Accept phrase-level reasons and invented spelling that does not block meaning.
Progressing (3–4)	A claim, two developed reasons, and one concession. Look for connectors — because, however, as a result — and for a closing sentence.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Sort ten pre-written reasons into For and Against columns, then copy two into the frame. Home-language notes welcome in the margin.
Emerging	Use the frames as written. Require three sentences minimum.
Progressing	Frames optional. Require a concession sentence beginning with "Some people say."
Challenge	Write the paragraph as a two-minute speech to the board and deliver it.

Sample response at Progressing

"I believe the school day should start later because teenagers need more sleep. One reason is that many students at my school ride the bus at 6:30 in the morning and cannot stay awake in first period. Another reason is that grades improve when students are alert. Some people say practice would end too late, but coaches could move practice to the morning. For these reasons, the district should move the first bell to 8:30."

Task 2 — Respond to a Message

Writing · Email

What it practices

Writing · correspondence for purpose and audience. Parallel to the ELPA21 email response task, where register and completeness both count.

Administration

Have students underline every question in the original email before they write. That single step raises completeness scores more than any other prompt.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Greeting, one answered question, closing. Accept short sentences.
Progressing (3–4)	Both questions answered, a question of their own, and a register that matches a peer — contractions fine, slang minimal.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Provide the reply with four blanks to fill. Read the original aloud twice.
Emerging	Frames posted. Require four sentences.
Progressing	No frames. Require the student to propose a specific day and time.
Challenge	Rewrite the reply twice — once to a peer, once to the principal — and annotate what changed.

Sample response at Progressing

“Hi Marisol, thank you for telling me about the lab. I can meet before school on Tuesday because I have work at lunch. Yes, please bring the data table so I can see the measurements, but I want to do my own calculations. One question I have is whether Ms. Pope wants one write-up or two. See you Tuesday,

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Task 3 — Observe and Report

Speaking · Club Sign-Ups

What it practices

Speaking · observe, summarize, and report from a visual. Parallel to ELPA21 tasks that ask students to describe information in a table or graph.

Administration

Model one sentence with a different data set first. Time the response at 60–90 seconds and record it on the Chromebook so students can hear their own fluency.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Numbers read correctly and one comparison, even in phrases. Comparative -er and 'more than' will be inconsistent; note it, don't stop the student.
Progressing (3–4)	Full sentences, accurate comparatives, and a conclusion that goes beyond restating a number.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Point-and-name: student points to each bar and says the club and number. Accept single words.
Emerging	Two frames required, partner rehearsal before recording.
Progressing	All four frames, no notes in hand.
Challenge	Add a claim: which club should get more funding, and what in the data supports that?

Sample response at Progressing

“The graph shows how many students joined each after-school club. The club with the most students is soccer, with fifty-two students. Soccer has thirty-six more students than art club. One conclusion I can draw is that sports attract more students than academic clubs at this school.”

Task 4 — State an Opinion

Speaking · Work and School

What it practices

Speaking · state and support an opinion. Parallel to the ELPA21 opinion task, which scores position, reasons, and elaboration.

Administration

Read the prompt twice. Give thirty seconds of silent think time and let students jot two words — not sentences — before speaking.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	A clear position and one reason. Accept a reason delivered as a short phrase with teacher prompting.
Progressing (3–4)	Position, two distinct reasons, an example, and a closing. Listen for sequencing language and for elaboration without prompting.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Agree or disagree with a thumbs signal, then say one reason from a posted list of five.
Emerging	Partner rehearsal first, frames visible while speaking.
Progressing	One minute unscripted, frames removed after rehearsal.
Challenge	Respond to a counterargument the teacher raises mid-response.

Sample response at Progressing

“I agree with the rule because work experience teaches things a classroom cannot. First, students learn to be on time and to talk to adults. Second, some students will find a career they like before they pay for college. For example, my cousin worked at a clinic and decided to study nursing. That is why I think the board should pass the rule, but they should help students find placements.”

Task 5 — Follow Instructions

Listening · Following a Procedure

What it practices

Listening · follow multi-step oral instructions and answer questions without text support. Parallel to the ELPA21 follow-instructions task.

Administration

Read the script below aloud twice at a natural pace. Do not show the text. Students may take notes. Ask the questions in order, allowing seven seconds of wait time after each.

Read aloud — do not show the text

Agua de jamaica is a cold drink made from dried hibiscus flowers.

1. Rinse one cup of dried hibiscus flowers in cool water.
2. Bring four cups of water to a boil, then turn off the heat and add the flowers.
3. Let the flowers steep for about ten minutes, until the water turns deep red.
4. Pour the liquid through a strainer into a pitcher and throw away the flowers.
5. Add four more cups of cold water and sugar to taste. Serve over ice.

Ask these questions, in order

- 1 How many steps are there?
- 2 What do you do before you boil the water?
- 3 What does *steep* mean in step three?
- 4 Why do you use a strainer?
- 5 What would happen if you added the sugar before straining?
- 6 What other drink could you make this way?

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Recalls the first and last step and answers two literal questions. Accept gestures and single words for vocabulary items.
Progressing (3–4)	Sequences all five steps, infers the meaning of <i>steep</i> from context, and answers the reasoning question about the strainer.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Give five picture cards to place in order while listening.
Emerging	Allow a third reading and note-taking in Spanish.
Progressing	Two readings, English notes, oral retell without notes.
Challenge	Retell the procedure in the passive voice, then write it as a recipe card.

Sample response at Progressing

“First, you rinse the flowers. Next, you boil the water and add them. After that, the flowers steep for ten minutes and you strain them out. Finally, you add cold water, sugar, and ice.”

Task 6 — Academic Lecture or Discussion

Listening · Science Lecture

What it practices

Listening · comprehend an academic monologue and answer literal and inferential questions. Parallel to the ELPA21 lecture task.

Administration

Read the passage aloud twice without showing the text. Ask the questions in order. Literal questions come first so every student answers something before the inferential ones.

Read aloud — do not show the text

The Mississippi sandhill crane is one of the rarest birds in North America. Unlike most cranes, it does not migrate. It stays in the wet pine savanna of coastal Mississippi all year. The birds are tall and grey, with long legs and a patch of red skin on the head. They feed in open, marshy ground and nest on the ground as well. As the savanna was drained and developed, the population dropped sharply, and the crane became one of the first species protected under federal endangered species law. A national wildlife refuge in Jackson County was set aside for it. Today, biologists raise chicks in captivity and release them into the refuge, and controlled burning keeps the savanna open the way the cranes need it.

Ask these questions, in order

- 1 What bird is the passage about?
- 2 Name two things the passage says about how the crane looks or where it lives.
- 3 What does *migrate* mean? How do you know?
- 4 Why did the number of cranes drop?
- 5 Why would burning the savanna help a bird?
- 6 What is one thing people are doing to help?

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Names the topic and one or two literal details. Accept fragments and repetition of the speaker's wording.
Progressing (3–4)	Main idea plus supporting details, a context-based definition of <i>migrate</i> , and a causal answer about habitat loss.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Provide four images — crane, marsh, fire, nest — and have the student point as each is mentioned, then name them.
Emerging	Third reading allowed; ask only the first four questions.

Progressing	Two readings; all six questions; require a summary in three sentences.
Challenge	Take Cornell notes during the second reading and write a paragraph on why habitat management matters.

Sample response at Progressing

“The passage was mainly about the Mississippi sandhill crane, a rare bird that does not migrate. One fact I remember is that it lives in wet pine savanna near the coast. The word migrate probably means to move to another place for the season, because the speaker said this crane stays all year. This is important because the bird almost disappeared when the land was drained.”

Task 7 — Extended Informational Set

Reading · Career Pathways

What it practices

Reading · integrate information across a passage and a graphic. Parallel to the ELPA21 extended informational reading set.

Administration

Have students read the passage once for gist and once with a purpose question. Question four is the one that separates lanes — it requires reading the graph and subtracting.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Locates explicit answers in the passage and reads values off the graph. Accept short answers for items 1–3.
Progressing (3–4)	Integrates both sources, computes the difference in item 4, and defines <i>pathway</i> without copying the sentence from the text.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Highlight the three sentences that answer items 1–3 in advance; student matches question to sentence.
Emerging	Answer items 1–4 in phrases; teacher scribes item 5.
Progressing	All six items in complete sentences.
Challenge	Write a paragraph arguing which pathway the school should expand, citing both the passage and the graph.

Answer key

- 1 Health sciences.
- 2 Ms. Ruiz, who worked as a respiratory therapist for nine years.
- 3 Computer networking.
- 4 Eight more students.
- 5 A group of classes that build toward a certificate, college program, or job.
- 6 Answers vary; must cite a detail from the passage or a number from the graph.

Task 8 — Short Paragraph

Reading · Biography

What it practices

Reading · short informational passage with literal, vocabulary, and inferential questions. Parallel to the ELPA21 short-paragraph reading task.

Administration

Preview three words before reading: *emancipation*, *epidemic*, *lynched*. The third requires care and context; handle it directly and plainly rather than skipping it.

Look-fors

Emerging (1–2)	Three literal facts and the reason she began teaching. Accept lifted phrasing from the text.
Progressing (3–4)	A method-level answer to item 3 (she gathered names, dates, and details and published them), a context-based definition of <i>rigorous</i> , and an inference supported by the passage.

Four lanes

Newcomer	Provide the passage with five sentences highlighted and a picture timeline; student matches four events to dates.
Emerging	Items 1, 2, 4 in phrases; partner discussion before writing.
Progressing	All six items in complete sentences.
Challenge	Write a paragraph on what makes reporting credible, using her methods as the example.

Answer key

- Any three: born into slavery in Holly Springs in 1862; orphaned by yellow fever; taught school as a teenager; journalist and newspaper co-owner in Memphis; investigated lynchings; helped found the NAACP.
- Her parents died and she needed to support her younger siblings.
- Lynchings across the South; she gathered names, dates, and details and published her findings.
- It was destroyed, and she could not safely return to Memphis.
- Careful, thorough, exact.
- Answers vary; must connect to her purpose or to the evidence she gathered.

Quick scoring guide

Score each response on two axes. Keep them separate — a student can be complete and inaccurate, or accurate and thin, and the instruction that follows is different.

Score	Completeness — did they do the job?	Language — how did the English hold up?
3	Every part of the prompt addressed, with elaboration beyond the minimum.	Connected sentences, appropriate register, errors that do not interfere.
2	Main part addressed; one required element thin or missing.	Simple sentences with some connectors; errors occasionally interfere.
1	Partial response; relies on copying the prompt or on the frame alone.	Words and phrases; meaning requires the listener or reader to work.
0	No response, or unrelated to the task.	Not enough language to evaluate.

Turning a score into a next step

- **Complete but thin language:** the student understands the task. Teach connectors and require one more sentence of elaboration next time.
- **Strong language but incomplete:** the student is not tracking every part of the prompt. Have them underline each required element before responding.
- **Low on both:** drop a lane for that task type, rebuild with the frame, and return to the full version in two weeks.
- **Three at the top twice in a row:** move the student to the Challenge lane for that domain and log it as growth evidence.